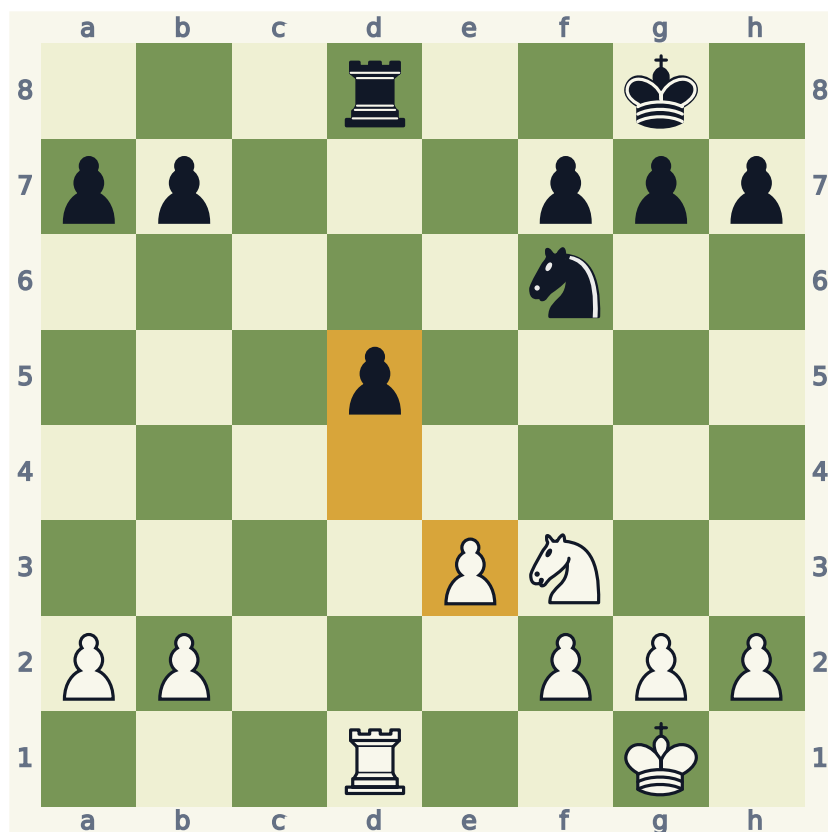


Restraint and blockade

Stop the freeing move before attacking the pawn.

Restraint limits a pawn's useful advances. A blockade places a piece directly in front of it. Knights are often effective blockaders because they can operate while staying on the square, but any piece may serve. First secure the blockade, then improve attackers and watch for a break that removes your support.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- d4 is the square directly in front of Black's d5-pawn.
- The e3-pawn supports a knight on d4.
- Black has no c- or e-pawn to chase that knight.

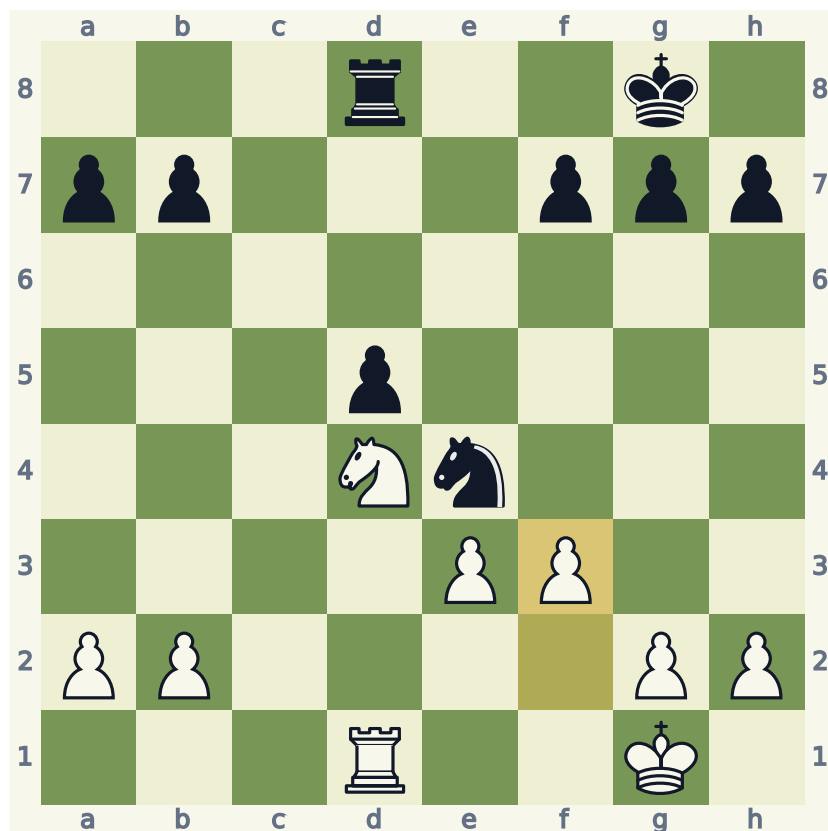
REMEMBER

- Check neighboring pawns before blockading.
- Support the blockader and give it active tasks.
- Watch for attacks on its supporting pawn.

Follow the logic

1. Nd4 Ne4 2. f3

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



Nd4

Stop ...d4 and install a supported blockader. The knight can also influence c6, e6, b5 and f5.

...Ne4

Black seeks an active post rather than passively waiting. The d5-pawn supports the knight on e4.

f3

Challenge the active knight. White must check king safety before moving this pawn in positions with queens or more attacking pieces.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

Black can exchange the blockader with a piece, attack e3, or create counterplay away from d5. White should keep the blockading piece useful and avoid tying down the entire army to one pawn.

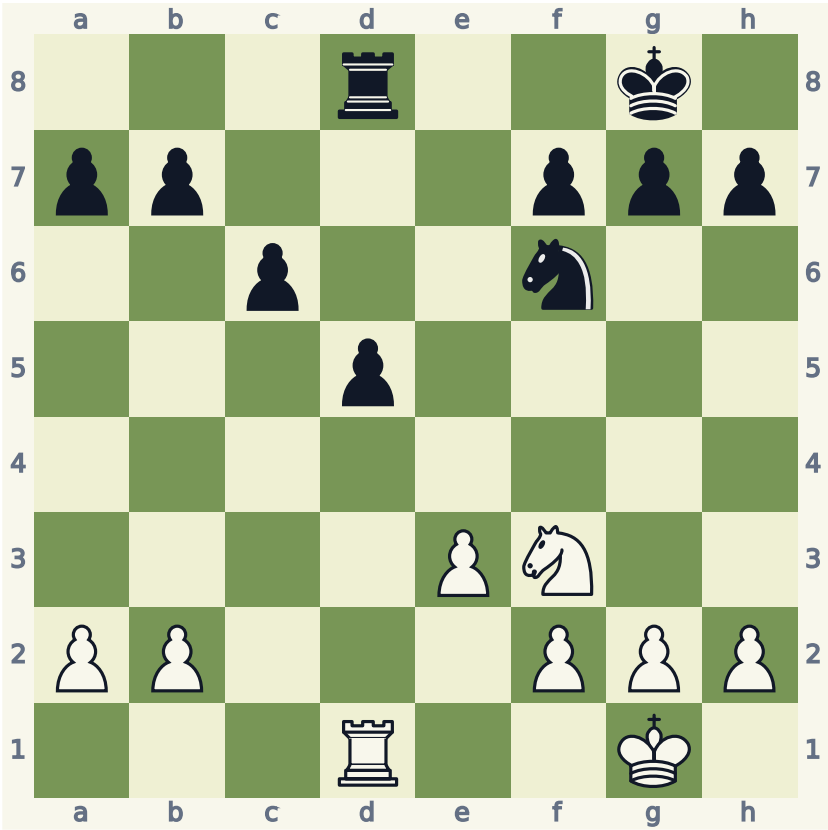
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

A blockade that leaves the blockader helpless elsewhere may be too expensive. Also, placing a piece in front of a pawn does not stop an adjacent pawn from capturing or undermining it.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. What extra resource does Black have in this version?
- 2. Why does Nd4 no longer establish a stable blockade?
- 3. What must White decide after ...c5?

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

What if White could prevent ...c5 without creating another serious weakness?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 3r2k1/pp3ppp/2p2n2/3p4/8/4PN2/PP3PPP/3R2K1 w - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. The c6-pawn can advance to c5 and attack d4. Unlike the isolated-pawn model, Black has a neighboring pawn that can challenge the blockader.
2. Nd4 is still legal and supported by e3, but ...c5 attacks it with a pawn. Pawn support does not make a knight safe to leave under a pawn attack.
3. White must find a safe knight move, exchange it favorably or calculate a tactical response. The plan should now focus on the changed pawn structure, not on pretending that d5 remains permanently fixed.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1. Nd4 c5

Changed feature: Then d4 might again become a durable blockading square. Restraint often has to come before occupation: stop the enemy's challenging pawn before installing the piece.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

List every way the defender can remove the knight in the model: pawn challenge, piece exchange, attack on support, or counterplay elsewhere.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 07, 13, 15. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.